

Navigating the ‘Southern Seas’, Miraculously: Avoidance of Shipwreck in Buddhist Narratives of Maritime Crossings

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1 Introduction

Within the vast region that I call ‘Maritime Asia’ (Acri, 2016, 2019), the sea was not a neutral space for dislocation, but a prime and fluid site – whether real or imagined – for interaction: between humans, between humans and nature, and between humans and supernatural agents.¹ In the context of this volume, the motifs of maritime travel and miraculous avoidance of shipwreck found in Buddhist narratives naturally lend themselves to being analysed against the wider theoretical framework of creolisation and mobility. A creolisation complex may arise from migrations, displacements and interactions across ocean routes; furthermore, as aptly noted by Rangan et al. (2015, p. 139; see also Rangan’s chapter in this volume), especially in the context of the Indian Ocean, human beings, plants and other realia moved along with stories. The circulation via the southern maritime routes of Buddhist monastic and lay agents – traders, artists, pilgrims, etc. – along with stories, cosmologies, texts and practices contributed to the shaping of a Buddhist cosmopolitan continuum articulated in Sanskrit and literary vernacular languages across much of Asia. These dynamics may add to our understanding of the networks and processes of creolisation in pre-colonial southern Asia; conversely, the concept of creolisation, not limited to narrow eighteenth- and nineteenth-century ideas of linguistic and racial mixing, could prove to be a powerful heuristic tool in

1 Early versions of this chapter were presented in a workshop organised at the Institute for Advanced Study, Stellenbosch University (South Africa) in August 2015, and in the special series of lectures commemorating Singapore’s bicentennial anniversary, ‘1819 and Before: Singapore’s Pasts’, organised by the Nalanda-Sriwijaya Centre at ISEAS-Yusof Ishak Institute in August 2018. I am grateful to Fernando Rosa and Terence Chong, respectively, for inviting me to present at those events. I also thank Vladimir Braginsky and Iain Sinclair for their feedback on a draft of this chapter, and gratefully acknowledge the help of Rolf Giebel and Iain Sinclair with the translation of relevant passages from the Chinese biographies of *Prajña; any mistakes are my own. Asterisks preceding personal names indicate that they are (often tentative) Sanskrit reconstructions from the original Chinese.

understanding the complex dynamics of intra-Asian transfer of Buddhism. As Buddhist texts and ideas crossed geographical and cultural contexts they were not only translated and adapted to local realities, but assumed new forms and lives, giving rise to novel paradigms that were exported to new 'frontiers' and, sometimes, even travelled back to their lands of (supposed) 'origin'.

This chapter hopes to contribute to the ongoing debate on creolisation by bringing into the discussion agents, materials, temporalities and geographies that are seldom associated with this phenomenon – namely, Buddhist monks, texts written in classical languages, the pre-modern ('medieval') period and the 'Silk Roads of the Sea' from the Bay of Bengal to the China Sea. It will focus on select Chinese, Sanskrit and Tibetan textual accounts, in particular the biographies of monks plying the sea routes between India and China from the fifth to the early eleventh centuries, to analyse and situate in their historical background the interwoven aspects of narrative, imaginary and factual data with respect to (miraculous) avoidance of shipwreck.² I will present the accounts by Faxian in comparison with the Chinese and Sanskrit versions of the Lotus Sūtra, then move to *Vajrabuddhi's³ and Amoghavajra's accounts and their comparison with the Vimalaśaṅkha episode in the *Mahāpratisarāvidyārājñī*. I will conclude with the Tibetan account of the journey of Atiśa to Suvarṇadvīpa, and a passage from the Classical Malay chronicle *Sejarah Melayu*.

2 Background: Networks of Seafaring Monks in Maritime Asia

As George Coedès pointed out long ago, the eastward expansion of Indic civilisation is to a considerable degree the result 'of a continual outflow of seamen, originally recruited from among "merchants of the sea", of whom many types are depicted in ancient Buddhist literature' (1968, p. 21). Indeed, the spread of Buddhism from the Indian subcontinent to Sri Lanka, South-East Asia and China via the maritime routes goes back to the early centuries of the Current Era – if not earlier, as testified to by the presence of Sri Lankan and South-East Asian toponyms in the *Mahāniddesa* and some Jātakas dating to between the late third and the first centuries BCE. Written and material evidence becomes more substantial from the fifth century onwards, testifying to an extraordinary efflorescence of long-distance maritime contacts, lasting for several centuries,

² I should point out at the outset that, being able to read neither Chinese nor Tibetan, I will undertake my analysis from the perspective of comparative literature rather than philology, and rely on editions and translations of primary sources produced by other scholars.

³ Hereafter I will adopt the form *Vajrabuddhi instead of the popular *Vajrabodhi as the most probable Sanskrit back-translation of the Chinese *Jingangzhi* 金剛智 (see Sinclair, 2016a).

across Maritime Asia. This vast geographical expanse of sea and land largely coinciding with a trans-regional 'Buddhist Cosmopolis' became the natural theatre for the journeys of hundreds of travelling monks who crossed the seas far and wide in search of texts, teachers and patrons. The vehicles of their travels were the monsoon-driven merchant ships that plied the maritime routes connecting a web of entrepôts linking the Indian Ocean to the China Sea, carrying alongside their valuable cargos also pilgrims, diplomats and, indeed, religious personalities of disparate affiliations.

Historical records going back to at least the third century CE provide us with a picture of a steady traffic of itinerant monks travelling both eastwards and westwards along the sea paths linking the swathe of territory comprising the Indian subcontinent and Japan (Pachow, 1960; Sen, 2014). It would seem that most of the monks travelling both ways between India and China preferred the maritime route to the overland one, or at least sought to include a maritime leg in their journey, which usually included stopovers in Sri Lanka and Nusantara. No less than twenty-five monks are recorded to have arrived in China in this way between 420 and 479 (He, 2008, p. 55), and a scholarly estimate records sixty-six individuals involved in the maritime transmission of Buddhism to China, out of the total estimated number of 103 monks (Kandahjaya, 2004, p. 78). The maritime mobility of Buddhist agents, besides being numerically significant, was also quicker and easier than hitherto assumed. A case in point is the episode of the establishment of female **bhikṣuṇīsaṅgha* in China via Sri Lanka in the course of just a decade in the fifth century by the South Asian monks **Guṇavarman* (Qiunabamo 求那跋摩, 367–431) and **Saṅghavarman*.⁴ By the eighth century, sea travel seems to have become an even easier undertaking, as suggested by the fact that the Central Asian monk Amoghavajra (Bukong 不空, 704–774) was even able to send back a Sanskrit text from China to his old master **Ratnabodhi* in Sri Lanka after translating it, and that several monks are known to have made it back to their places of origin, like the Indian **Parāmiti*, who reached Canton by 705 and went back his homeland by boat, or the Korean monk Hyecho (fl. eighth century, one of Amoghavajra's disciples), who travelled to India twice within his lifespan – at least once, it seems, via the maritime route (Pachow, 1960; Deeg, 2010a).

In spite of the remarkable maritime mobility of Buddhist agents, both the Jātaka tales and the Sino-Japanese and Tibetan biographies of monks travelling

4 The latter reached China in 438 on the ship of a non-Chinese merchant called **Nandin* (Zhu Nanti) – the same individual who had brought the former to Sri Lanka and China, and who is credited with the translation of some Sanskrit Mahāyāna scriptures into Chinese (Deeg, 2010b, pp. 157–158; Silk, 2002, pp. 31–32).

from China to India and/or vice versa make clear that travel across the maritime trading channels linking the two regions was not devoid of perils. Besides imagined entities such as marine monsters, Nāgas and other supernatural beings, the most feared hindrances in the minds of the travellers were storms, unfavourable winds, pirates, and unskilled or unscrupulous crews. Faxian's account of his maritime journey to China is striking not only for being the earliest, but also for providing rare and lively details around his momentous voyage on a large, 200-passenger-strong merchant sailing vessel. Faxian's misfortunes are echoed in the biography of Vajrabuddhi (671–741) by Luxiang, and similar circumstances are associated with Vajrabuddhi's disciple Amoghavajra when he was travelling on a South-East Asian ship (*Kunlun bo* 崑崙舶) from China to Sri Lanka in 741. The biographers of the Indian monk Prajña report that his sea journey to Guangzhou in China, where he arrived in 781, was marred by multiple setbacks, taking in all about twenty years (Pachow, 1960, p. 210; Copp, 2011, p. 361). Another Indian monk, *Mañicintana or *Ratnacinta (Baosiwei 寶思惟, d. 721), randomly escaped death during a storm on his way to China, while the Chinese monk Chien-chen/Ganjin (688–763) allegedly attempted the dangerous crossing of the sea that separated China from Japan six times before finally making it in 754 (Forte, 1984, pp. 301–302).

In a recent article, Himanshu Prabha Ray (2012) discusses Buddhist narratives of sea travel in the context of translocality across the Bay of Bengal as well as specific sites in the subcontinent, such as Bharhut, Mathurā, Kanheri, Ellora, Ajanta and Ratnagiri. The widespread presence of maritime scenes of navigation and shipwreck – depicting sea travel in its political, spiritual and economic ramifications – in sites located on/near the coast or along trading routes in South Asia, Sri Lanka, and South-East Asia (such as Borobudur and Angkor) suggests that those scenes, rather than being conceived of as purely symbolic and metaphysical representations of spiritual dangers, were linked to an imaginary grounded in literary heritage as much as actual experience.⁵ This, in turn, testifies to the increasing popularity of maritime travel in Buddhist communities from the sixth century onwards. The concurrent development in the same locales of 'saviour cults' focusing on the Bodhisattvas Avalokiteśvara, Tārā (especially in her *aṣṭamahābhaya* aspect) and Mahāpratisarā as protectors of travellers, and of sailors in particular, against the perils encountered

5 See Lévi, 1931, p. 597: 'A large number of the stories of the Pali Jataka has drawn materials from the adventures in the sea. The sea and its navigation evidently occupied a large place in Indian life in the period when these stories were conceived'. The same is also the case in such texts as the *Bṛhatkathāślokaśaṅgraha* by Budhasvāmin, the *Ratnāvalī* by Harṣa, the *Kathāsaritsāgara*, etc.

along their journeys may be due to the increasing number of merchants and monks plying the commercial routes.⁶ The material and art historical evidence is matched in pre-seventh-century Buddhist texts such as Jātakas, the *Divyāvadāna*, the *Mahāvastu* and the *Saddharmapuṇḍarikāsūtra*.

3 Faxian

Faxian 法顯 (337/342–ca. 422) was among the first Chinese monks to have reached India by land and sea travel. The account of his journey, the travelogue *Gaoseng-Faxian-Zhuan* 高僧法顯傳 (*The Biography of the Eminent Monk Faxian*) is the earliest in its genre. The portions that concern us here are those narrating his disastrous passage to China via Sumatra or Java and the narrow avoidance of catastrophe – shipwreck first, then a hostile crew.

Having spent some years in north-eastern India (i.e., Nālandā) and Sri Lanka to acquire copies of various important Sanskrit texts – all of which were unavailable in China – Faxian, in 408 or 409, travelled on a mercantile ship (*yānapatra*) from the eastern Indian port of Tamralipti to Sri Lanka, and from there on a large boat to China via South-East Asia. Between Ceylon and Sumatra, on the third day after setting off, the ship ran into a storm that lasted for thirteen days:

After having received these Sanskrit-texts (in Ceylon)⁷ (Faxian) embarked on a big trade-vessel which had about 200 persons on board; in the back a smaller vessel was tied (to the big one), because travelling by sea was dangerous in case that the big vessel got shipwrecked. They encountered favourable monsoon winds heading east; but after three days they encountered a violent storm and water penetrated the vessel. The merchants wanted to enter the small vessel, but the people in the small vessel feared that this would mean too many people and cut the rope. The merchants feared for their lives and were afraid that the ship would

6 At Ajanta and Kanheri, Avalokiteśvara is depicted in association with the ten dangers, including shipwreck, sometimes along with Tārā (Ray, 2012, p. 57; see also Brancaccio, 2017, pp. 67–68); at Aurangabad cave 7 we find a depiction of a shipwrecked two-mast oceanic ship, carrying a passenger clad in a foreign guise, in the panel on *aṣṭamahābhaya* Avalokiteśvara (Brancaccio, 2017, p. 69). In Ellora cave 9, the function of Avalokiteśvara is taken over by Tārā in her *aṣṭamahābhaya* form, and the same is the case in the Orissan sites of Ratnagiri (Ray, 2012, p. 59). On Avalokiteśvara as ‘Saviour of sailors’ in Sri Lanka, see Bopearachchi, 2014.

7 In this quotation and any below containing both parentheses (round brackets) and square brackets, the former are additions by the cited author while the latter are mine.

be filled with water. So they threw all the unnecessary cargo overboard into the sea. Faxian, too, threw his water-pot, his water-bowl and other stuff into the water, but he was afraid that the merchants would get rid of his sūtras and statues. So he called upon Avalokitasvara [Guanshiyin 觀世音] with devotion and took his refuge in the whole *saṅgha* of China saying: 'I have gone so far in order to seek the dharma I (now) beg for this immense stream of water to be calmed'. After having been in this storm for thirteen days they (finally) reached the shore of an island. After the high tide had gone out again they saw the leak in the ship and repaired it. After that they set off again. (Deeg, 2010b, p. 156)

The thirteen-day storm mentioned by Faxian probably took place in between Sri Lanka and the Andaman or Nicobar Islands, where the ship is likely to have eventually landed (Deeg, 2005, pp. 179–185). The detail about the smaller boat attached through a rope to the main vessel, which would have functioned as a 'tender' or life-boat in case of shipwreck, is interesting, and conforms to a relief representing just such a tender boat attached to a larger vessel on eighth-century Borobudur in Central Java (Illustration 2.1). Further, the mention of the potential casting overboard of the cargo – including manuscripts and sacred images – by the merchants strikes me as realistic, as it is in harmony



ILLUSTRATION 2.1 Ship, Borobudur, Java
SOURCE: ANDREA ACRI

with the protocol of seamanship in this type of event.⁸ This lends credibility to Faxian's account (we will encounter this detail again in the other narratives presented below), and is also indicative of the less-than-idyllic relations between traders and Buddhist monks, especially in real-life emergency situations: rather than invoking Faxian's help to appease the storm through prayers or supernatural powers, they rush to throw overboard the passengers' personal effects – including, Faxian fears, his precious Buddhist scriptures, no matter their sanctity.

In the continuation of his account, Faxian describes the perils of sea travel:

Often there were pirates at sea and if one encountered them one could not come out of it unscathed. The big ocean extends without limitation and no direction is recognised; only the movement of the sun, the moon and the stars can be observed. When the sky is covered or if it rains the ship is driven along without even having these means of orientation. After nightfall one sees huge waves grapple with each other as if they were fire-coloured giant turtles, crocodiles (or) other kinds of sea monsters. The merchants were very frightened because they did not know in which direction they sailed. The ocean was deep and (seemed) bottomless and there was no place where they could cast anchor. Only when the sky brightens up could one again recognise the direction, reposition the ship and continue the journey. If reefs are encountered there is no way to survive (this disaster). (Deeg, 2010b, p. 156)

Having sailed for ninety days, the ship ran ashore on the land of Yepoti 耶婆提 (presumably *Yavadvīpa, i.e. Java, or Sumatra) where, Faxian reports, Brahmanical and other non-Buddhist teachings were flourishing while Buddhist presence was negligible. The account continues as follows:

8 A similar note of realism is found in the episode of shipwreck narrated in the *Saṅkha Jātaka*, where the Brahmin Saṅkha travels to Suvarṇabhūmi by sea, and also in the *Mahājānaka Jātaka* (both involving the intervention of the saviour-goddess Maṇimekhala). In both accounts, instead of weeping and crying like the other crew members, the protagonist fills his stomach with sugar and clarified butter, wears tight dresses soaked in oil, cling to the top of the mast, then jumps into the water ('full of blood'), taking care to avoid the sharks that are making carnage of his companions. This strikes me as a real-life procedure to increase one's chances of survival at sea (in the *Saṅkha Jātaka*, the protagonist does indeed survive for seven days in the water before being rescued by Maṇimekhala). See Lévi, 1931, pp. 599, 603, 606.

Faxian stayed in this country for about five months until he went aboard of another merchant ship with about two hundred people. They loaded food supplies for fifty days and put to sea on the sixteenth day of the fourth month. After Faxian had settled on the ship it headed north for Guangzhou.

After one month at sea, on the stroke of the second hour at night they encountered a black wind and vigorous rainfall. All the merchants were afraid. Again Faxian begged Avalokitasvara [Guanshiyin 觀世音] and the *saṅgha* of China for support. At daybreak all the brahmins met and discussed the matter saying: 'It is because this *bhikṣu* is with us, that we are in such trouble and great misery. We should maroon the *bhikṣu* on an island. We do not need to be in such danger because of one person'. But Faxian's *dānapati* (lay supporter) said: 'If you maroon the *bhikṣu* then you have to do the same to me. Otherwise kill me. If you maroon this Sramana and I reach China (country of the Han), I will go to the ruler and report on you. The ruler of China is a supporter of the Buddhist dharma and pays reverence to the *bhikṣu* and to the *saṅgha*'. Thereupon the merchants hesitated and did not dare to abandon Faxian.

At that time it was continuously clouded; although the officers of the ship observed (the sky) they committed (navigational) mistakes. After more than seventy days they ran out of food supplies and water. They used seawater for cooking and distributed fresh water in portions of two *sheng* a person, but they still ran out of it. The merchants discussed the situation and said: 'Under normal conditions the journey to Guangzhou lasts fifty days. It is not normal that after so many days we still have not arrived there!' (Ibid., pp. 156–157)

Two details are striking here: the first is the reference to the incident between Faxian, the Brahmins on board the ships, and the crew, which may reflect, just like in the previous passage, the complex and at times difficult relationship between Buddhist monks and traders (Sen, 2014, pp. 42–43); the second is, again like in the previous passage, the prayer to Guanshiyin/Avalokiteśvara to avert disaster.

As pointed out by Hu and von Hinüber (2015), the above passages bear resemblance to excerpts from Dharmarakṣa's Chinese translation of the Lotus Sūtra. This scripture, which triggered the worship of Guanshiyin in China, was known to Faxian (unlike Kumārajīva's translation of 406), and might therefore have influenced Faxian's account.⁹ The passages run as follows:

9 See Hu and von Hinüber, 2015, p. 312; cf. Deeg, 2005, p. 572, fn. 2515.

[佛國記 T51: 866a7–14]

There are many pirates on the sea. If one encounters them, then the whole (crew) will perish. The great ocean spreads itself out endlessly, so that one has no sense of direction. Only by observing the sun, moon and stars was it possible to proceed on course. If it is cloudy and rainy, (the ship) is driven onwards by the wind without any guidance. In the darkness after the nighttime, one only sees the great waves wrestling each other and emitting a bright color like that of fire, with giant turtles, crocodiles and other sea monsters. (In such a situation) the merchants became very frightened and didn't know in which direction they should navigate. Because of the depth of the bottomless ocean, there is nowhere to drop the (perpender) stone. The right direction can only be found again when the sky becomes light. Then the (seamen) can reorient (the ship) and navigate it in the right direction. If she collides with any hidden rock, there is no way to survive. (Hu & von Hinüber, 2015, p. 315)¹⁰

[正法華經 T9:129a2–10]

Imagine that millions upon millions of people set out into the deep and bottomless ocean in order to search gold, silver and different pearls; the legendary wish-pearl like the bright moon; crystal and lapis lazuli; mother of pearl and agate; coral and amber; and their ship was fully loaded with those treasures. Suppose a powerful tempest had shipwrecked their vessel in whirling waves like black mountains, crossing the area of demons Yakṣa and encountering the fish–devils Makara. If only one person among the crew prayers [*sic*] to the dread and goodness of Bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara and calls out his name, all of passengers would be freed from the distress and demons. Because of this (mastery) he is called Avalokiteśvara. (Ibid., p. 316)¹¹

The wording of the description of the dangers encountered in the ocean shows evident similarities with the account of Faxian, as does the injunction that

10 Here I have reproduced Hu and von Hinüber's rather than Deeg's translation in order to render the comparison between the two texts exactly as it has been presented by them.

11 Compare the Sanskrit *Saddharmapuṇḍarikasūtra* 289 (Wogihara & Tsuchida, 1958, p. 362), which explicitly mention the 'demoness' island' (*rākṣasīdvīpa*; cf. below): *sacet punaḥ kulaputra sāgara-madhye [...] sa potas teṣāṃ kālīkāvātena rākṣasīdvīpe kṣiptaḥ syāt tasmīṃs ca kaścid evaikaḥ syāt yo 'valokiteśvarasya bodhisattvasya mahāsattvasyākramāṇi kuryāt sarve te parimucyeraṃs tasmād rākṣasīdvīpāt*. Compare 24.6: *saci sāgaradurgī pātayen nāgamakarasurabhūtālaye / smarato avalokiteśvaraṃ jalarāje na kadāci sīdati*, 'If one happens to fall into the dreadful ocean, the abode of Nāgas, marine monsters and demons, he has but to think of Avalokiteśvara, and he shall never sink down in the king of waters'.

one person among the crew should pray to Avalokiteśvara. The latter can be identified as a recurrent trope in Buddhist hagiographical literature. For instance, Huijiao 慧皎 (approx. 497–554) reports that the South Asian monk *Guṇabhadra 求那跋陀羅 (394–468), who arrived in Guangzhou in 435, prayed to Avalokiteśvara during his sea voyage from Sri Lanka to China, when there was neither wind at sea nor drinking water on board (Deeg, 2005, p. 572). This situation led Hu and von Hinüber to conclude that 'for future studies on the travel journals of Chinese pilgrims to India, such as Faxian, Xuanzang (玄奘) and Yijing 義淨, their relation with the canonical scriptures should be taken more into account, as most of the scriptures were thoroughly studied by these learned monks' (Hu & von Hinüber, 2015, p. 318). This is certainly the case, as there is ample evidence of intertextuality and cross-pollination between genres – the travelogues presenting an intriguing mix of literary images and factual data.¹² In the next section I will show that the same situation is reflected in the biographies of Vajrabuddhi and Amoghavajra, which echo Faxian's account on the one hand and a Sanskrit scriptural source – the *Mahāpratisarāvidyārājñī* – on the other.

4 Vajrabuddhi and Amoghavajra

The fortuitous events experienced by Faxian call to mind the similar circumstances narrated in Luxiang's biography of Vajrabuddhi,¹³ another famous Buddhist master who travelled by sea from India to China via the Indonesian archipelago (i.e. Sumatra and Java). Quoted by his pupil Amoghavajra in his tale of the Iron Stūpa, Vajrabuddhi himself recounts the following:

I set forth from the western country (India) to cross the southern ocean [to Java] in a fleet of more than thirty great ships, each one carrying more than five or six hundred persons. Once, when we were crossing in convoy in the very middle of the great ocean we ran into a typhoon. All the ships we depended upon were tossed about (like drift-wood), and the ship I was on was about to be inundated. At that time I always kept the two scriptures [i.e. the full and abridged versions of the *Vajraśekhara*]

12 Of course, there may be more at stake than just literary tropes, namely the oral dimension/human element: for instance, since Guṇabhadra collaborated at Daochang temple with Baoyun 釋寶 (376–449), a junior friend of Faxian who accompanied him during part of his journey to India (Glass, 2008), it is possible that the detail about Avalokiteśvara in Guṇabhadra's account might have been inspired by either Baoyun or Faxian himself.

13 As found in Yuanzhao's 圓照 (late eighth century) *Zhenyuan xinding shijiao mulu* 貞元新定釋教, *New Bibliography of the Buddhist Teachings*.

I was bringing nearby so that I could receive and keep them and do the offerings. Now, when the captain saw that the ship was about to sink, everything on board was cast into the ocean, and in a moment of fright the one-hundred-thousand-verse text was flung into the ocean, and only the superficial text was saved. At that time I aroused my mind in meditation, doing the technique for eliminating disasters, and the typhoon abated, and for perhaps more than a quarter mile around the ship wind and water did not move. All on board took refuge in me, and bit by bit we got to this shore and arrived in this country. (Sundberg & Giebel, 2011, p. 147)

It is then recounted that ‘Only the single ship carrying His Reverence was able to escape this disaster because he recited the [*Mahāpratisarā-dhāraṇī*] (*Sui-qiū*, 隨求)’ (Chou, 1945, p. 275, fn. 19; Sundberg & Giebel, 2011, p. 139). These events occurred when the master was twenty days short of reaching the Chinese coast, thus probably in South-East Asia.¹⁴

Besides the trope of the storm, Vajrabuddhi’s and Faxian’s accounts have a few elements in common, namely: both of them recounts events that must have happened in the proximity of Java or Sumatra; the protagonists are two Buddhist monks travelling to China (via South-East Asia) on a merchant ship and carrying some important texts with them; both manage to avert disaster by means of a *dhāraṇī* – to *Mahāpratisarā* in the case of the former and *Guan-shiyin/Avalokiteśvara* in the case of the latter. Whereas Faxian manages to save his precious Sanskrit texts, Vajrabuddhi ends up losing some of them, including the full version of the *Vajraśekhara*.

Scholars have cast doubt on the veracity of Vajrabuddhi’s account. For instance, Gray, having pointed out that this is one of the few eyewitness accounts of an esoteric Buddhist text in manuscript form spanning one hundred thousand stanzas (2009, p. 13), argued that the episode of its loss might have been fabricated, and that, ‘even if Vajrabodhi had such a text, the logic of tantric discourse would require that it be jettisoned’ (ibid., p. 14).¹⁵ According to Eastman

14 Vajrabuddhi’s travels from Sri Lanka to China are considered factual by Sundberg (Sundberg & Giebel, 2011, p. 148) on account of the matching chronology of his meeting with Amoghavajra in Java. It is interesting to note that Amoghavajra’s presentation of the storm story perfectly accords with the chronology proposed by Chou (1945): Amoghavajra quotes Vajrabuddhi in the third person, confirming that the loss of the text occurred on the initial approach to China in 716, when Amoghavajra was not there. Sundberg also considers the shipwreck account historical; having noted that ‘the textual baggage brought on the same ship by Vajrabodhi was so terribly mistreated’, he suggests that its being thrown overboard may ultimately ‘have been a question of the accessibility of various items in the hold of the ship’ (Sundberg & Giebel, 2011, p. 189).

15 See in particular Orzech, 1995 and 1996, for the idea that Vajrabuddhi might have concocted the account to ‘esoterise’ the text and legitimise its transmission through initiation imparted by himself and his lineage.

(1981, quoted in Meinert, 2016, p. 345), 'it was the stormy socio-political winds that prevented a full translation of all texts at the time', probably because their sexual and 'violent' elements were deemed improper in the prevalent Buddhist and non-Buddhist religious discourse in China. Yet, even if the circumstances narrated in the account may reflect personal agendas and contemporary anxieties, as well as be modelled after standard tropes in Buddhist hagiographical literature, I believe that they cannot be entirely discounted as pure concoctions given that sea travel and shipwreck were common realities in Buddhist milieux, and are backed up by textual, art historical, and archaeological evidence. For instance, a similar circumstance is reported by Chinese monk Xuanzang (600?–664), who lost some scriptures while he was crossing the Indus river on a boat on his way back to his homeland.¹⁶ The tone of the passage strikes me as down-to-earth, and verisimilar:

His scriptures and images were loaded in a boat with his companions to sail across the river, while the Master waded through the river on his elephant. He had appointed a man in the boat to take care of the scriptures and some seeds [...] When the boat sailed to midstream, a turbulent gale suddenly arose. The waves tossed the boat and almost overturned it. The man who was asked to look after the scriptures was so frightened that he fell overboard, but was rescued by the other passengers. Fifty bundles of scriptures and flower seeds were lost, while his other property narrowly escaped damage. (Li, 1995, p. 157)

The detail about the loss of these texts is reported elsewhere in Xuanzang's biography: 'As the master had lost some scriptures while crossing the Indus, he sent someone, after arriving in this country, to Kucha and Kashgar to seek new texts' (ibid., p. 167); 'When I was crossing the Indus [on my way back home], I lost a pack of scriptures. I am now sending you herewith a list of the lost texts, of which I request that you send me new copies by some convenient messenger' (ibid., p. 233). There is nothing supernatural about Xuanzang's dispatch of an envoy to look for copies of the lost texts; more importantly, this fact mirrors Vajrabuddhi's dispatch of his disciple Amoghavajra to Sri Lanka – a journey that the latter actually undertook and accomplished successfully, and which resulted in the translation of a longer/more developed version of the *Sarvatathāgatatattvasaṅgraha* into Chinese.¹⁷

¹⁶ Cf. also Prajña's biography (see p. 64).

¹⁷ It seems to me natural to ask why Vajrabuddhi would send Amoghavajra to look for the non-abridged version of the text if he had wanted to maintain this tradition as the sole preserve of himself and his lineage, and to keep the teachings of the text in their

The same circumstance of the recitation of the *Mahāpratisarādhāraṇī* to avert shipwreck while travelling by sea is associated with Vajrabuddhi's disciple Amoghavajra when he was on his way from China to Sri Lanka in 741:

In the twelfth moon of the twenty-ninth year (AD 741) he left Nan-hai on board a K'un-lun [i.e. Malay] ship. When they reached the boundary of Kaliṅga [i.e. Java] they met with a heavy storm. Each merchant, being terrified, tried to propitiate (the gods) by the method of his own country, but without result. All of them knelt down to pray for help and protection. Hui-pien and other disciples also wept bitterly. Amoghavajra said: 'I have a plan. Don't worry'. Thereupon, with a five-fingered *vajra* of Bodhicitta in his right hand and the *Prajñāpāramitāsūtra* in his left hand, he recited once the *Mahāpratisarādhāraṇī* and performed the rite (required for this *dhāraṇī*). The wind subsided immediately and the sea became calm and clear. Later they came across a large whale, which, emerging out of the sea, emitted jets of water like a mountain. It was even more threatening than the previous calamity and the merchant were ready to give up their lives. Amoghavajra performed the rites as before, and told Hui-pien to recite the *So-chieh lung-wang ching*. At once all the dangers disappeared. (Chou, 1945, p. 290)

Just like in the passages quoted above, it is possible that the circumstances narrated in the account may have been based on standard tropes from Chinese hagiographical literature rather than actual fact (Goble, 2016, p. 136, fn. 51); however, the information found in the Taisho canon that in 758 Amoghavajra actually submitted a copy of the *Dhāraṇī of the Great Protectress Who Is Universally Radiant, Pure, Incandescent, a Wish-Granting Gem, and the Sealed Essence of the Invincible King of Mantras* (普遍光明清淨熾盛如意寶印心無能勝大明王大隨求陀羅尼經, that is, the *Mahāpratisarādhāraṇī*) to Emperor Suzong (T2120.829b2–21) to be carried as an amulet confirms that Amoghavajra had access to a version of this text, and transmitted it to East (and, possibly, South-East) Asia.¹⁸

As noted by Hidas (2012, p. 222, fn. 178, and p. 224, fn. 184), both Vajrabuddhi's and Amoghavajra's accounts are similar to that expounded in the fifth narrative in the central and longest text in the *Mahāpratisarā*-corpus, the Sanskrit

'crystallised' versions. I find it more plausible that Amoghavajra's travel was moved by a genuine quest for authentic/'updated' scriptures and teachings.

¹⁸ Compare T2057.294c23–24, where it is said that Huiguo sought instruction in the mantra of Pratisāra from Amoghavajra between 763 and 765 (Sinclair, 2016b, p. 38, fn. 52).

Mahāpratisarāvidyārājñī,¹⁹ in which the merchant Vimalaśaṅkha saves his ship from a storm, lightning and meteors sent by Nāgas. On that occasion, Vimalaśaṅkha writes down the *Mahāpratisarādhāraṇī* and fixes the amulet to the top of a flagstaff. To the distressed companions approaching Vimalaśaṅkha, the trader replies (Hidas, 2012, pp. 222–224):

'Fear not, fear not, merchant gentlemen. Calm down. I shall save you from this ocean of trouble [...] I have the famous great spell, called 'Amulet' [i.e. the *Mahāpratisarādhāraṇī*]. It subdues all the wicked, being of great power and might. I am going to save you from this intense suffering and great danger with it'.

Then, at that time, the great trader painted the Great Amulet, Great Queen of Spells, and fixed it at the top of a flagstaff. Immediately after the Great Amulet had been fixed at the top of the flagstaff, all those Timiṇilas saw the ship transform into a single mass of flame. Then those Nāgas, becoming benevolent, approached them and began to pay them reverence. The Timiṇilas, having been burnt by the might of this Great Amulet, Queen of Spells, fled and were destroyed. The merchants were led by those great Nāgas to a distinguished Great-Jewel Island.

This great spell, the Great Amulet, is endowed with wisdom and it is empowered by all the Tathāgatas. This is why, Great Brahmā, it is called a great spell. It should, by all means, be held fixed at the top of a flagstaff. It calms all types of winds, cold-spells, untimely clouds, lightning and thunderbolts.

In contrast to the accounts of Vajrabuddhi and Amoghavajra, the Vimalaśaṅkha episode is markedly imaginific, with the exception of the detail regarding the employment of a drawing of the *Mahāpratisarādhāraṇī* at the top of a flagstaff. This detail may have reflected an actual practice, for the fixing of a magic item to a flagpole to produce supernatural results is a trope in Buddhist Sanskrit texts.²⁰ Other narratives around the rescue of Buddhist sea-voyagers by saviour

19 The *Mahāpratisarāmahāvidyārājñī* is the central and longest text in the *Mahāpratisarā*-corpus, which underwent considerable elaboration during centuries of textual transmission, as can be seen from the variety of manuscripts that have survived of this once highly popular text. An edition and translation is Hidas (2012).

20 See, e.g., a passage preceding the sixth narrative of the *Mahāpratisarāmahāvidyārājñī*, prescribing the veneration of a *Mahāpratisarā* amulet mounted on a flagpole on a caitya (Hidas, 2012, pp. 224–225); and a passage in *Avadānaśāta* (2.14), prescribing the tying of a robe to a flagstaff to be paraded across a kingdom affected by plague. To Granoff (1998, p. 298), the account 'provides some details of the rituals that might well have actually been done in Buddhist India to put an end to plagues'.

deities usually mention the recitation of a mantra or *stotra*,²¹ a meditation focusing on the elected deity, or the performance of a ritual procedure.

While the account of Vajrabuddhi might have influenced the one of his disciple, it is also possible that the three accounts may have been inspired by a common source – either textual or oral narrative sources on the maritime crossings of merchants and monks circulating in Java and Sumatra, including Faxian's. An account by Yuanzhao compiled into the *Zhenyuan xinding shijiao mulu*, as well as the Japanese master Kūkai, record that Vajrabuddhi first met Amoghavajra in Java (Chou, 1945, p. 321; Sundberg & Giebel, 2011, p. 152). The chain of transmission could have gone back and forward in time beyond Vajrabuddhi and Amoghavajra, for we know about two other prominent monks who experienced difficulties in Southeast Asian waters, namely Mañicinta(na), who arrived in Loyang in 693, and who first translated (a lacunose version of) the *Mahāpratisarādhārāṇī* into Chinese in the same year (T1154);²² and Prajña (Boruo 般若, alt. Bolaruo 般刺若, 744–ca. 810), who shipwrecked and got stranded on a beach, thereby losing all his scriptures except a manuscript of the **Ṣaṭpāramitāsūtra* that was lying there, and which he eventually translated after he arrived in China (T788).²³

21 In addition to the passages discussed in this contribution, see, e.g., the introduction of a Sanskrit commentary to the *Tārāstuti* by Candradāsa, relating an anecdote regarding the composition of the hymn: 'This Master Candradāsa, when he was onboard of a ship at sea while the ships were shattered through winds etc., uttered with great devotion, in order to name the subject of the Stotra (*stotrārtha*), [devoted] to the noble Tārā, in the beginning [i.e. as its first verse] the promise to express [Tārā's] virtues that surpass all the three worlds; [this he did by] indicating the connection [the reason for composing the work?], the subject, the purpose, etc. Through the excellence of his words the water retreated from that place' (Hanneder, 2008, p. 176). The passage is significant insofar as the tension between liturgical *stotras* and literary *stotras* 'is here resolved by explaining the religious efficacy of the Stotra through its literary qualities' (ibid., p. 176, fn. 30). An altogether similar legend is associated with Candragomin, who indeed authored a series of *stotras* to Tārā preserved in the Tibetan canon; these *stotras* describe shipwreck and other dangers of sea travel (see ibid. p. 183, and *Sragdharāstotra* by [the Kashmirian!] Sarvajñamitra, ed. Vidyabhusana, 1908, pp. 16–17, 117).

22 Mañicintana is credited with the Chinese rendering of the *Amoghapāśakalparājasūtra* (不空罽索陀羅尼自在王咒經, *Bukongjuansuo tuoluoni zizaiwang zhou jing*, *Scripture of the Amoghapāśadhārāṇī*, *Sovereign Lord of Spells*, T.1097; Orzech et al., 2011, p. 82, fn. 26; p. 270); Amoghapāśa is a manifestation of Avalokiteśvara whose lasso saves those in danger. Interestingly, a report by Su Ting on Mañicintana's maritime travel to China narrates about the latter's encounter with a statue of Avalokiteśvara in the Southern Seas (Forte, 1984, p. 307).

23 Chou, 1945, p. 322; Copp, 2011, p. 361. Prajña's account may be found in the *Zhenyuan xinding shijiao mulu* (T2157:891c26–892a4; cf. T2156:755c16–a16). I thank Rolf Giebel and Iain Sinclair for summarising its contents to me.

Whether actual or imagined, the above-mentioned accounts speak in favour of the popularity of Mahāpratisarā and the spell she personifies, the *Mahāpratisarādhāraṇī*, among Buddhist travellers – monks and traders alike – and match the material evidence on the propagation of her cult across the Buddhist world via the maritime routes. Mahāpratisarā was especially popular in the monastic institutions of eastern India, and was made the object of a nearly pan-Asian cult. Various textual and iconographical attestations of this protective deity are documented in Java, especially from the eighth to the tenth centuries, as well as in Bali, Sumatra, and Mindanao in the Philippines.²⁴ A gold foil recovered from the ca. tenth-century Cirebon shipwreck off the north coast of Java, containing a *dhāraṇī* addressed to an unnamed goddess, and paralleling material found in the *Ekādaśamukhadhāraṇī* and *Sādhanaṃālā*, confirms that these types of object were actually worn by passengers and/or crews as amulets intended to protect against the dangers of voyage at sea (Griffiths, 2014, pp. 157–159).

5 Atiśa

The imaginary and supernatural elements became predominant in the biography of the famous eleventh-century Eastern Indian monk Atiśa (also known as Dīpaṅkaraśrījñāna, 980–1054), who left the subcontinent to study for a few years in Sumatra (or the Malay Peninsula) with *Sauvāradvīpī-Dharmakīrti and then went to Tibet. Atiśa joined a group of merchants from Nepal (!) sailing to the Golden Island in search of precious stones. He too encounters difficulties during his crossing of the Indian Ocean, namely a storm supernaturally caused by the Hindu god Śiva, who tries to stop him from leaving India to study the dharma. To defeat Śiva and his consort, Atiśa and his disciple Kṣitigarbha manifest themselves as wrathful tantric deities; the latter 'launches a preemptive strike against the enemies of Buddhism, including Hindus, Muslims, and practitioners of the Bon religion in Tibet' (Decleer, 1995, p. 532). Excerpts of the account are quoted below:

I, the monk Dīpaṅkaraśrījñāna, for thirteen months was on board a ship, on my way into the presence of the guru of Golden Island. When five months had passed [on board], a son of the gods (*devaputra*), Maheśvara, in order to destroy my aspiration to achieve enlightenment for the sake of others (*bodhicitta*), caused a storm to move in, blowing in the wrong direction. Changing himself into the great Makara ('Fish Swallower') sea monster, he

24 See Mevissen, 2009; Crujisen et al., 2012; Orlina, 2012.

obstructed (our passage) in front. From the sky he caused a thunderbolt to fall right on top of me. At that time, due to my meditating on loving-kindness (wishing all beings to be happy) and compassion (wishing no living being to experience suffering), the tempest was completely calmed and I saw six great bolts of lightning stuck motionless in the sky.

Yet the Makara sea monster was still blocking (our progress) in front, and the surface of the ocean was being churned about by this strong wind with such force that this ship of ours, too, like a prayer flag flapping in a strong wind, was rocking and rolling all about. One moment it was lifted toward the sky, the next moment it seemed to be plunging into the very depths of the ocean. The four great banners, one in each direction, broke off. Although four massive iron weights had been let down (as anchors) into the depths of the ocean from each of the four directions, it was as if a massive drum was being beaten, with a howling noise, a thundering sound, light (at the horizon) and great flashes of lightning erupting, all of which made every one of the companions extremely frightened. As they were thus trembling in fear, again I entered into equipoise, meditating on loving-kindness and compassion. (Decleer, 1995, p. 535)

Imaginific elements aside, the account strikes me as a lively and quite accurate depiction of an actual incident at sea – witness the mention of the massive weights used as anchors to stabilise the ship during the tempest. The detail of the throwing overboard of anchor-stones fastened to the ship with chains during a storm is also found in the Sanskrit *Kathāsaritsāgara* and the Prakrit *Samāicca Kahā* (Schlingloff, 1988, pp. 99, 212, note 107), and must have reflected an actual best practice of seamanship.

The section of the account following thereupon contains a long and elaborate narrative featuring invocations to Raktayamāri, Tārā and Avalokiteśvara, and the transformation of Atiśa and Kṣitigarbha into the Krodha-vighnāntaka deities of Raktayamāri and Acala, respectively. This section resonates with the passages on the conquering of Maheśvara and other harmful beings by protectors of the dharma that we find in Vajrayāna texts. The setting moves from the ocean to the Hindu city of Svabhānātha (in northern or eastern India?), the Turk city in Afghanistan, and Sri Lanka, infested by demon-cannibals. After these locations are struck and burnt down by rays emanating from Kṣitigarbha, the two resume their usual aspect, and the account continues:

For twenty-one days we were utterly unable to continue, but as soon as we were truly safe from further fear, on each of the four directions (of the ship) we raised the great wind banners, we hauled up the four massive Iron (anchor weights). Then, as an opportune wind arose for one and a

half months without break by day or night, we remained on the great ocean and proceeded.

After seven months had passed, again, from in front, a storm arose and we were driven back by the wind over the distance of one day's travel. I prayed to my guru, to the precious three, and to the Ḍākinīs and dharma protectors. Soon storm subsided by itself, yet a strong wind in the right direction failed to arise. Because of the (little) merit of the sentient beings (on board), half a month was lost there, in which I meditated on the aspiration to enlightenment based on loving-kindness and compassion. Eventually a right wind arose and we took off again. It took us a further two months and twenty-six days to reach the shore across the ocean. (Decleer, 1995, p. 540)

The account apparently does not follow factual space and time. All in all, the atmosphere of Atiśa's narrative is quite different from that of the accounts we have examined so far, ridden as it is with supernatural elements: the storm and danger of shipwreck appears to be just a pretext to strike and attack the enemies of Buddhism in the subcontinent and overseas. Most curious is the detail (repeated twice) that the boat on which Atiśa is travelling is 'Nepalese' – an oddity, given that Nepal is a landlocked and predominantly mountainous country; perhaps we have to understand that a Nepalese party of merchants 'chartered' the ship. Intriguingly, a Newar reminiscence of Atiśa's sea journey to insular South-East Asia may be the vignette dedicated to an image of the Buddha Dīpaṅkara – also considered the protector of the sailors – in Java in the early eleventh-century illustrated manuscript of the *Aṣṭasāhasrikā-Prajñāpāramitā* (CUL Add. 1643, folio 2 recto).²⁵ Further, Sinclair (2016c, p. 165) has noted that the identification of an image of the Buddha Dīpaṅkara at Thaṃ Bahī, the monastery founded by Atiśa, with the merchant Siṃhalasārthavāha ('caravan-head Siṃhala') of *Dīvyāvadāna* 36 etc. may be a vestigial memory of Atiśa's journeys. Indeed, both the Sanskrit and Newar versions of the *Siṃhalasārtha Avadāna* contain a narrative of shipwreck.²⁶ In the latter version the protagonist, a merchant travelling with 499 companions, having been shipwrecked on the river

25 Indeed, one notes the near absence of textual and iconographical evidence relating to this Buddha in Java – although, according to Sinclair (personal communication), there is the possibility that some Nusantara images could have been hitherto misidentified as 'standing Buddhas' or 'Śākyamunis'.

26 Cf. also the *Sārthavāhajātaka* (*Avadānasārasamuccaya*, ed. Handurukande, 1984), verses 2–19 in particular, whose general tone and specific wording (describing the frightful ocean and its denizens, including *timīṇilas* and *makaras*, and resorting to the help of a Bodhisattva) present resemblances to the above-quoted accounts by Faxian, the *Saddharmapuṇḍarikasūtra* and the *Mahāpratisarāvidyārājñī*.

Brahmaputra reaches the country of Ratnapura in Tambradvīpa, inhabited by flesh-eating demonesses (*rākṣasī*), and manages to save himself thanks to the intervention of Avalokiteśvara. The Nepalese version most likely originated from an early version of the *Divyāvadāna* included in the *Kāraṇḍavyūha*, a text related to Avalokiteśvara. The island of the *rākṣasīs* is obviously Sri Lanka, or Tambradvīpa, also mentioned in the *Saddharmapuṇḍarīka* (cf. above, fn. 11). These details are found in Atiśa's account: 'One ray of light [emitted by Kṣitigarbha] struck Lanka, the country of the cannibal-demons, and put a stop to the cannibal-demons' tradition of eating human flesh' (Decleer, 1995, p. 539). In the Newar version of the Siṃhala story, this episode was 'localized' and 'domesticated' so as to adapt it to a more familiar regional landscape (Lewis, 1993); thus, it seems to reflect the concerns of trading families, i.e. the dangers of travelling, including the constant fear of shipwreck (Appleton, 2006). In a similar way, the narrative of Atiśa's sea-passage is to be situated in an environment of maritime travel and cultural contacts between the subcontinent/the Himalayan region and South-East Asia,²⁷ which tells us a lot about the state of Buddhism in India at that time and apparently reflects the anxieties of contemporary Buddhist circles.

6 The *Sejarah Melayu*

A short passage on supernatural avoidance of shipwreck is found in the 1612 CE recension of the *Sejarah Melayu* (*Sulalatus Salatin*) or *Malay Annals*, a Classical Malay chronicle recounting earlier events related to the sultanates of the Straits of Melaka, among which is the journey of the ruler of Palembang Nila Utama Paramesvara Bhatara Sri Tri Buana to the island of Bintan in the Riau archipelago and his consecration as king of Temasek (i.e. present-day Singapore). One of those events is Nila Utama's sea voyage, believed to have taken place in the late thirteenth or early fourteenth century, that is, still during the Hindu-Buddhist period, when the East Javanese kingdoms of Singhasari and Majapahit exerted political and cultural influence on Sumatra after the decline of Śrīvijaya. In chapter 3 Nila Utama, who is now married to queen Wan Sri Bini of Bintan, embarks on a maritime journey to Tanjong Bemban

27 Recently, Sinclair (2016c, pp. 164–166) has argued that the eight-armed form of Amoghapāśa (whose earliest representations come from the Śrīvijayan domains) in the Thaṃ Bahī monastery in Nepal could have been introduced in memory of its founder Atiśa, and specifically to remember his journey to the Golden Isles, many years after the fact. Both Atiśa and Sauvarṇadvīpi-Dharmakīrti were fervent devotees of Tārā, whose cult was widespread in maritime South-East Asia and may have been popularised in Tibet by Atiśa after his stay in Sumatra or the Malay Peninsula.

and sees Temasek across the water. Crossing to it, he encounters a storm and is compelled to throw overboard all the cargo until nothing remained but his own crown:

When they were come out into the open sea, a storm arose and the ship began to fill with water. Bale as they might they could not clear her and the boatswain gave order to lighten the ship. But though much was thrown overboard, they still could not bale the ship dry. She was by now close to Tělok Blanga, and the boatswain said to Sri Tri Buana, 'It seems to me, your Highness, that it is because of the crown of kingship that the ship is foundering. All else has been thrown overboard, and if we do not do likewise with this crown we shall be helpless with the ship'. And Sri Tri Buana replied, 'Overboard with it then!' And the crown was thrown overboard. Thereupon the storm abated, and the ship regained her buoyancy and was rowed to land. (Brown, 1952, p. 30)

The account of the crossing of the Straits by Nila Utama contains some familiar narratological elements: the storm, and the need to jettison the cargo – including the protagonist's crown – to avert shipwreck. Just as Vajrabuddhi loses the precious complete version of the *Vajraśekhara* tantra, so Nila Utama loses the royal diadem, which, by being thrown overboard, ultimately causes the storm to dissipate and the boat to land safely. It is possible that a literary trope might have been at play in both accounts – the one 'magico-ritual', the other (predominantly) 'royal'. In the case of Vajrabuddhi, as we have seen above, the episode of the loss of the full *Vajraśekhara* could have been dramatised to legitimise the monk as the originator of an esoteric initiatory tradition in a foreign country. In the case of the *Sejarah Melayu*, the detail about Nila Utama's royal crown being so 'heavy' that it needed to be thrown overboard lest the ship sink suggests that this act fulfilled a symbolic and metaphysical aim: before landing in a foreign land and being crowned as its new ruler, the powerful 'Stranger King' should be deprived of his sovereignty. It is significant to mention here that Braginsky has detected a nucleus of shared narrative motifs between the *Sejarah Melayu* and other Classical Malay texts, as well as (East) Javanese Pañji romances (Braginsky, 2005, pp. 119–126, and note 37; 2015, p. 94, fn. 35). These specimens combine the motif of the shipwreck with that of the drowned crown and the prince who is thrown by the waves to the shore of the country, where he marries the local princess and becomes king.²⁸ In order

²⁸ The texts from Sumatra and the Malay Peninsula include the *Tambo Minangkabau* (shipwreck in Singapore Straits, lost crown, recovery under the sea, Braginsky, 2015, pp. 107–108; crown lost and retrieved in the sea of Sri Lanka, *ibid.* pp. 93–94); the *Sejarah*

to do so, the hero often becomes a character of low social status, and then is upgraded to his new kingly status. This basic myth, belonging to an (archaic?) ‘royal cluster’, has been transformed in the course of time under the impact of religious and cultural ideas (Hindu, Buddhist and Islamic).

In view of the above, I think it is not beyond the realm of possibility that the Nila Utama-Tri Buana episode in the *Sejarah Melayu* could have been inspired by textual accounts or oral narratives popular in Sumatra and Java during the Hindu-Buddhist period. This hypothesis has already been voiced by Braginsky (2005, esp. chapter 2)²⁹ and Wolters (1970, esp. chapter 8), who described the connection of this text and its author (a genealogist/performer) with Śrīvijaya. Like Wolters, Kwa (2010, pp. 144–147) has regarded the *Sejarah Melayu* as a covertly Buddhist text, permeated by a worldview and political ideology stemming from the type of Sanskrit Mahāyāna/Mantranaya Buddhism practised in Śrīvijaya.³⁰ Furthermore, the text calls Nila Utama the ‘ruler of the whole of Suvarṇabhūmi’, and declares him to be the son of Saṅ Sapurba, ruler of Palembang, and brother of Sang Maniaka. As noted by Winstedt long ago (1938, p. 2), the names of these three characters apparently derive from those of the three heavenly nymphs (*apsaras*) Suprabhā, Tilottamā and Menakā featuring in Sanskrit texts, such as the *Mahābhārata*, as well as the eleventh-century East Javanese *kakavin Arjunavivāha*, as part of Indra’s entourage. Hooker and Hooker (2001, p. 40) argued that ‘at various times and in a number of places, elements of the *SM* narrative were selected for incorporation into other narratives and “localized”’, and therefore the various versions of the *Sejarah Melayu* need to be considered in terms of a ‘larger corpus of narratives, each of which is aligned with some basic tenets of the *SM* tradition, but which add their own

Melayu (shipwreck and recovery of young prince by toddy tapper from Majapahit, Brown, 1952, pp. 72–75); *Hikayat Merong Mahawangsa* (prince survives shipwreck, Braginsky, 2015, pp. 113); and *Hikayat Hang Tuah* (king of Melaka and Hang Tuah simultaneously lose their crown and kris in the sea, *ibid.* p. 94 fn. 35, 153 fn. 53).

29 See also Braginsky, 2015, pp. 92–93, who detects intriguing parallels between the *Tambo Minangkabau* and the 1347 Padang Candi inscription issued by Ādityavarman, as well as the East Javanese *Kuṅjarakarna*.

30 It is worth stressing that the Śrīvijaya thalassocracy in Sumatra hosted renowned centres of Buddhist activity and higher learning by the seventh century, as documented by Chinese monk Yijing, who praised the high level of Buddhist scholarship he found there, where he stopped – en route from Guangzhou to Nālandā and from there back to China – to read Sanskrit Sūtras. The high level of scholarship and sustained royal sponsorship is confirmed by the evidence of the study of the abstruse Prajñāpāramitā and Abhisamayālaṅkāra literature, as well as the figures of Shihu/*Dānapāla (d. 1018), an exceptionally prolific monk-translator who in the late tenth century who reached China with a good knowledge of the languages of Sanfochi/Śrīvijaya and Shepo/Java (Sen, 2003, p. 384, Orzech, 2011, pp. 449–450), and of the distinguished Sauvarṇadvīpī-Dharmakīrti.

local inputs'. As we have seen above, this seems to have also been the case in such narratives as the *Siṃhala Jātaka*, *Dīvyāvadāna*, *Kāraṇḍavyūha*, etc. It may thus be argued that the author(s) of the (various versions of the) *Sejarah Melayu* borrowed the account of avoidance of shipwreck from an earlier source – which might in turn have derived from a Mahāyāna scripture, a Jātaka or even a monks' travelogue – reworking it in an original way and stripping out the Buddhist element so as to suit the Islamic fashion of his/their time. In conclusion, the *Sejarah Melayu* could quite aptly be considered an agglomerative, syncretic and hybrid literary source – a prototypical 'creole' text indeed, composed in a geographical milieu that has been the theatre of dynamics of ethnic, linguistic and cultural creolisation.

7 Conclusion

The material discussed in this chapter suggest that the motif of maritime travel, and the related images of ships and shipwrecks, clearly held a place in the imaginaries of the cultured elites of the pre-modern societies of southern Asia – not only those inhabiting the littoral and insular regions across the Bay of Bengal and the China Sea, but also those of the landlocked regions of Tibet, Nepal and continental China. Several sources belonging to different genres and written in different languages across a span of a thousand years – Buddhist sūtras in Sanskrit and their Chinese translations, Chinese hagiographies and travelogues, the Tibetan biography of an eleventh-century eastern Indian Buddhist master, and a hybrid Classical Malay chronicle – share the core motif of wondrous avoidance of shipwreck by a protagonist during his crossing of the 'Southern Seas' – be he a Buddhist monk plying the maritime routes from India to China, a merchant or fictitious character travelling to Sri Lanka or Java in search of wealth, or a 'Stranger King' sailing to his new kingdom. Some narratives share the motif of the intervention of a deity or supernatural force in favour of the protagonist, others the throwing overboard of important/magically charged objects. Some of the accounts strike us for their verisimilar description of calamitous events, as if they were rooted in the author's or protagonist's own experience; others for their markedly imaginary character, as if they were drawing on established literary imagery; and others – probably the majority – for a mix of both. All of them are characterised by an element of providence, yet without undermining the agency of their protagonists.

The accounts of Faxian, Vajrabuddhi and Amoghavajra, as well as the Vimalaśaṅkha episode in the *Mahāpratisarāvidyārājñī*, are similar in that they share the trope of the 'miraculous response' (*ganying* 感應), which in the

Chinese Buddhist tradition ‘refers to the spiritual power (*ling* 靈) possessed by certain religious objects that can be awakened through acts of devotion’ (Liu, 2016, p. 23). While recent scholarship has often questioned the accuracy or truthfulness of these and other Chinese medieval travelogues, Liu (*ibid.*, p. 5) has highlighted the circumstances and various stages in which they were composed, and the inherently polyphonic nature of their narrative voices. Reading Faxian’s biographies *Gaoseng-Faxian-Zhuan* and *Foguo ji* 佛國記 (*A Record of Buddhist Kingdoms*) as ‘heterogeneous accounts’ belonging to a genre mixing verifiable historical information with legends, oral traditions and anecdotes (*ibid.*, p. 3), he has pointed out that in monastic settings, when scriptures were translated orally into Chinese, the audience was given an opportunity to ask questions and raise problems (*ibid.*, p. 13); in the case of the Daochang Monastery, where Faxian may have been asked about his travel experiences, there would also be foreign monks with knowledge of the geography and customs of the regions visited by the Chinese monk, including South-East Asia. Therefore, although Faxian’s accounts were based on his personal experience, they might have been supplemented and revised during their composition, so as to match both local Chinese context and the experiences of foreign monks. Faxian’s travels and activities ‘entered into historical memory, becoming a tale (*gushi*) circulated throughout later generations and exerting great influence within the monastic tradition’ (*ibid.*, p. 24) and mixing historical facts pertaining to his travels with other narrative details that ‘would continuously evolve over the course of the story’s circulation and retellings, with additional interpolations made by those who retransmitted it’ (*ibid.*, p. 14). Similar dynamics could have intervened in the compilation of the Chinese biographies of Vajrabuddhi and Amoghavajra, as well as in the Tibetan biography of Atiśa and the Malay chronicle *Sejarah Melayu*.

Apart from reading those narratives as repositories of literary tropes, I have argued that they match quite well the available historical evidence: for example, they are associated with a group of monks who translated into Chinese a body of related texts (e.g. the *Mahāpratisarādhāraṇī*, the *Amoghapāśakalparāja*, *Mahāyānasūtras* and *Mantranaya* texts, the *Gaṇḍavyūha/Bhadracarī*, etc.); were particularly devoted to saviour deities (Avalokiteśvara/Amoghapāśa Lokeśvara, Tārā, Mahāpratisarā, Dīpaṅkara, etc.); and visited Sumatra and/or Java, either on their way to China or as their main destinations, as in the case of Atiśa. The shipwrecks found off Java and Sumatra, some of which carry Buddhist paraphernalia and, as we have seen above, even a protective *dhāraṇī*, testify to the existence of a traffic of Buddhist monks and to the insidious nature of Indonesian waters. This state of affairs leads me to think that the

Mahāpratisarādhārāṇī was a 'must bring' item in the baggage of every monk travelling by sea from the seventh to the tenth century.

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Moving Spaces

*Creolisation and Mobility in Africa, the Atlantic and
Indian Ocean*

Edited by

Marina Berthet
Fernando Rosa
Shaun Viljoen



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